

GOLDEN BOUGHS
Activists hug trees at a village in Uttarakhand's Chamoli district, 1982

Photograph by **BHAWAN SINGH**

A MIGHTY CANOPY

» **The Chipko Movement culminated in the Forest Conservation Act of 1980**

» **It made policy makers realise that local communities have right over natural resources and therefore must be seen as caretakers**

» **The movement underscored the significance of women in the economy and in conserving ecology**



"Our movement goes beyond the erosion of the land, to the erosion of human values. If we are not in a good relationship with the environment, the environment will be destroyed, and we will lose our ground"

— CHANDI PRASAD BHATT,
Founder, Dasholi Gram Swarajya Sangh

DID YOU KNOW?

The Chipko women activists were inspired by an incident in 1730 where 363 Bishnoi people were killed by the Maharaja of Jodhpur's men when they resisted the chopping of trees in Khejarli village by hugging them

a socio-economic movement, Chipko ('to cling to' in Hindi) inspired activists in India and beyond in their fight to save ecosystems against the depredations of mining, hydropower projects, industrialisation and urbanisation.

Though the immediate impact of the Chipko movement was a withdrawal of lumbering contracts in the hills and a ban on commercial tree-felling in the Himalayan forests region in 1980, it also made policy makers realise that local communities have a right over the environment. The Chipko ethos resonates in policies for management of forests and wildlife. The guidelines for Environment Impact Assessment, where local communities participate to voice their concerns against a mining or infrastructure development project, has its origins in Chipko, as does the Forest Rights Act, 2006, that gives tribals and other dwellers land rights and ownership of forest resources and minor produce. ■